

Recognizing Social Engineering

Rather than hacking a system, scammers target people and seek access to sensitive information through social engineering. This is a tactic used by cybercriminals for 98% of cyber attacks. Social engineering is the act of manipulating or deceiving in order to gain access to sensitive information. These are seven ways that scammers manipulate people through social engineering.

1. Creating Urgency

Scammers want you to act before you have time to think.

They might say:

- “Your account will be closed today.”
- “You must act immediately.”

Always take your time and follow the principles of Stop-Verify-Ask.

Legitimate organizations will rarely require immediate action.

2. Pretending to Be Someone You Trust

Scammers may claim to represent organizations like Medicare, your bank, Social Security, or other organizations that play an important role in your life. You should always directly contact the organization using a phone number or website you know is legitimate.

3. Offering Something That Seems Too Good to Be True

Examples could include:

- Lottery prizes
- Unexpected inheritances
- Investment opportunities with “guaranteed” returns

Things that sound too good to be true usually are.

4. Using Fear or Threats

Scammers may threaten you by saying your accounts would be suspended, you would be arrested, or you will stop receiving benefits from the organization. In these situations, always take a deep breath and verify

whether the information is correct. Call someone you trust before making any decision in these situations.

5. Asking You to Keep It Secret

When someone tells you that you cannot tell your family or your bank about this “confidential” thing, remember that legitimate organizations will never ask you to keep financial matters secret from trusted people. Scammers want you to keep things secret so that they will not get caught.

6. Building Trust Over Time

Sometimes scammers take weeks or even months building a relationship with a person and gaining their trust before they ask for sensitive information. Always remember to never send money to someone you only know online.

7. Impersonating Family Members

Scammers may pretend to be a relative or someone close to you and may claim that they need money for an emergency. Always contact that family member directly using a phone number you already have in these situations.

These are not the only ways that scammers exploit older adults through social engineering. Always consult with someone you trust if something seems suspicious.

Artificial Intelligence and Social Engineering

Artificial intelligence is now being used often by scammers to generate deepfakes. Deepfakes are when scammers create a video to impersonate other individuals, whether it be a close relative, a manager at an organization you trust, or someone that you know. Scammers sometimes even create a synthetic video call when you may believe you are talking to the actual person but are actually talking to a deepfake. Voice cloning is also done to impersonate the voice of someone you know or trust. In these situations, always hang up and directly call the contact from your phone.

Ultimately, social engineering is dangerous and has led to several scams. However, by being cautious and always verifying, you can prevent yourself from falling for these terrible scams.

References

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